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NATURALISED IN MADRAS

Atho is a gift Indians repatriated from Burma gave to Madras. And by owning and relishing this dish, Madras gave them a sense of connection **P4**



CLUB GETS STUDENTS CURIOUS ABOUT SPACE

The Department of Mathematics of Stella Maris College organised a host of events to celebrate National Space Day **P7**



A slippery course on CPR Salai



On the morning of August 29, 2026 knots of workers were furiously removing mud from parts of CP Ramaswamy Salai. The urgency had been triggered by the slippery ride motorcyclists were having on account of these spots. Mud had accumulated at various parts of the road after these spots had been dug up for infrastructural work by Tangedco. With the trenches filled with mud, rain scattered it and made for wet earth, dangerously slippery earth. The spots that were sporting mud included the one by the side of the bridge, the one by the side of Shilpi Boutique and the Billroth Hospital junction. PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK

Three-day exhibition of Krishna dolls in Gopalapuram

Krishna Janmashtami celebrations will be held on September 4 from 6 p.m. onwards at Shree Geeta Bhavan, Avvai Shanmugam Salai, Gopalapuram. This is the 36th year of the celebration organised by the Shree Geeta Bhavan Trust, said a release.

Meenakshi Chitharanjan, Bharatanatyam exponent, will inaugurate the three-day Krishnavatar exhibition and distribute prizes to students who have participated in the inter-school competitions.

Sweets for Krishna Jayanthi

Sri Krishna Sweets will be introducing Krishna Jayanthi special boxes filled with handpicked festive sweets and savouries. The box consists of mysurpa, therattipaal, boondi laddu, milagu seedai, adhirasam, aval mixture, classic thattai, sweet seedai and kai murukku. Toll-free no. 1800 102 2343.

READERS WRITE

Cars parked haphazardly at South Mada Street

SONY

On South Mada Street in Mylapore, haphazardly parked cars is a regular sight. Lack of discipline in parking these vehicles causes a huge inconvenience to senior citizens making it difficult for them to walk freely. The pavements are already encroached upon and haphazard parking only adds to this chaotic situation.

Traffic police should take necessary steps to clear the congestion.

Sony is a resident of Venkatesha Agrharam



This image was taken on August 11. PHOTO SRINATH M

Motoring made difficult at street in Mylapore

MOHAMED AZMAL A

Residents and commuters using VSV Kovil Street in Mylapore are facing significant difficulties due to the poor condition of the road. The road surface has deteriorated over time, with several potholes and uneven sections making travel uncomfortable and unsafe.

Potholes create challenges for commuters, especially motorcyclists, who are forced to manoeuvre carefully to avoid accidents and vehicle damage. During rains, the roads go from bad to worse. Rainwater accumulates in the potholes and on the damaged road surface, creating water stagnation that hides the actual depth of the potholes.

In addition to safety concerns, prolonged water stagnation can ac-



celerate further road deterioration and contribute to public health issues by creating favourable conditions for mosquito breeding.

Mohamed Azmal A is a resident of Mylapore

MMC batch of 1976 to meet on September 11

VARADARAJAN KALIDASAN

Our batch of Madras Medical College, the Batch of 1976 which was selected to undertake the MBBS course during the Emergency Period of 1976, is now coming together again to celebrate its Golden Jubilee. Many of us have not met each other for four decades or more.

Over the years we have worked in different parts of the world, from far-flung Australia, New Zealand, Southeast Asia, South Africa, the United Kingdom and the United States of America. Many of us have contributed significantly not just to the healthcare of the people around the world but towards research, education and administration. Some have made huge contributions within India too, including serving in the Armed Forces. Wherever we have been, we have flown the flag high for our country and our institution.

Examples of such people include Prof. Vani Rao at the Johns Hopkins University, USA; Prof. Murali M. Chintagumpala at the Texax Children's Hospital, Houston; Prof. C. Rajkumar at the Brighton and Sussex Medical School; Prof. V. Kalidasan who has been previously director of medical education in Brighton and held honorary ap-



pointments including in China and at the Royal College of Surgeons in Edinburgh. In India Dr. Amar Agarwal and his wife Dr. Athiya (also from our Batch) have created the chain of the famous Agarwal Eye hospitals; other famous practitioners include Dr. Lakshmanan of the AVM hospitals in Thoothukudi, Dr. Vimallesh Lysander from Lysander hospital in Virudhunagar and Dr. S. Sridhar in MIOT hospitals. These are but a few examples of those who have cared for and contributed to our society and we cannot forget Colonel Dr. Anbunathan who was a paratrooper and served in the Indian Army with great distinction.

In addition, through the contact we have with the Rotary Club (in which Dr. Mahender, from our batch and his wife Dr. Anuradha are very active) we are participating in a campaign called the Pink



A group photo of the Batch and snapshots of other get-togethers.

Auto Project. Our batch has collected sufficient funds to fund five autorickshaws which will be given to five suitable women chosen by the Rotarians. This will help them to sustain their families independently. We are also donating two defibrillators (AEDs) to be placed in suitable public locations where



they could be life-saving. It is to be noted that out of a possible 120 classmates over 110 are making the trip to the meet. We have unfortunately lost 21 classmates over the years. We will remember them on this occasion with great fondness.

We are meeting at the old campus of the Madras Medical College

near the famous Red Fort Anatomy building on September 11, 9 a.m. We will be having a group photo and participate in a campus walkaround.

(Dr. Varadarajan Kalidasan, who practises in England, is an alumnus of Madras Medical College from the 1976 batch)

NITYA V

When Asha (name changed) joined V-Excel's Youth Empowerment Services Unit in early 2023, she came with a simple aspiration: to become a contributing member of society. Cognitive and psychological health challenges, coupled with limited awareness at home, had left her with low self-esteem. Today, Asha lives with dignity and pride. She works at a prominent bakery and café in Chennai, contributing financially to her family.

Looking ahead, she aims to establish her own bakery and employ her peers.

Asha's transformation reflects a broader story – one of thousands marking V-Excel's 25-year evolution from a modest local project into a comprehensive movement for neurodiversity and social inclusion.

A vision takes root

A quarter of a century ago, conversations surrounding disability in India were largely confined to medical diagnoses. In Chennai, a small initiative set out with a different vision: creating a world where children with special needs could learn, participate, and thrive with dignity.

For founder-director Vasudha



25 and going strong

As V-Excel Educational Trust entered its 25th year on August 29, a close look at how it has been building pathways for children and young adults with special needs

Prakash, V-Excel Educational Trust emerged from years of professional and personal experiences. Her background in clinical psychology, experience in child-centered education abroad, and doctoral studies in the United States provided the academic grounding. However, it was the persistent voices of Indian parents seeking structured support for their children that turned vision

into action. V-Excel Educational Trust was established not merely as a response to disability, but as an answer to the uncertainty and lack of opportunities facing families.

Building the foundation

The organisation's initial milestone was an integrated teacher-training programme designed to help educators understand children as indi-

viduals rather than diagnostic labels. This initiative laid the groundwork for the Kaleidoscope Learning Centre (KLC) a full-time special school operating on an anthroposophy-inspired curative approach. KLC was built on a core philosophy: children are defined not by what they cannot do, but supported to discover what they can become. The training programme inspired many educators, including former trainees who went on to establish their own inclusive education models.

In 2005, an Early Intervention Unit was established at M.G. Road in Adyar for children aged 0 to 7, bringing vital community focus to early identification and developmental support. Partnering with the ESVI Sarada Foundation in 2006, V-Excel opened a Vocational Training Unit in Adyar to prepare young adults for independent, dignified living. In 2014, Youth Empowerment Services was launched in Mylapore, broadening avenues from self-employment to open employment across hospitality, manufacturing, and finance – proving that inclusion means earning, creating, and belonging.

Café Samarth and Tiffin Times: Trainee-run initiatives were adults gained practical workplace experience managing kitchen duties, customer service, and sales.

Thozhi: An enterprise focused on manufacturing low-cost sanitary napkins.

Vikasith: A finishing school programme providing soft-skills training and job-readiness preparation to facilitate smooth integration into the regular workforce.

Nitya V is a special educator with V-Excel Educational Trust that runs centres in Adyar, Mandaveli and Mylapore. This article was co-written with inputs from other team members.

Beyond Chennai

V-Excel's geographical growth evolved organically through community relationships and local partnerships in Villupuram, centre in Nashik, and regional centres in Tirunelveli (2011), Erode (2012), Srirangam (2015), Pollachi (2017), Tiruvannamalai (2023), and Kolapakkam (2023), bringing specialised services directly to rural families.

Workplace exposure

V-Excel has consistently developed visible, practical platforms for adults with special needs to engage with the public and gain workplace exposure.

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Atho is a gift Indians repatriated from Burma gave to Madras, their new home. And by owning and relishing this dish, Madras gave them a sense of connection with their past, people and culture as return gift

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

People marry into money. Abdul Rahman married into "Atho". And the latter situation translates to money saved by the plates. "I have never had to pay for a plate of Atho after marriage," Rahman chuckles.

Rahman is the son-in-law of Abdul Ajeez, whose eponymous Ajeez Atho Shop at Arrababu Street off Rajaji Salai in George Town has the effect of a speed governor on an environment geared to movement and bustle. The milling crowd on Rajaji Salai contrasts with the stationary, slurping crowd around Ajeez's shop. Customers, their work bags slung over their shoulders, tuck into plates of Atho as if it were their comfort food.

Atho shops in this part of George Town present these two scenarios. Local residents "own" Atho as one would a home-grown dish, treating it as a gift from Madras; a good number of them are likely unaware of the Burma backstory. And those Indians who left Burma (now Myanmar) for Madras find that connection with the Burma of the past sustained through Atho's popularity in this city. Through it, they also enjoy a sense of community among their own. Take these illustrations.

At Arrababu Street, Ajeez Atho Shop is at a vantage point enjoying

clear visibility from Rajaji Salai but patronage does not derive entirely from that factor. Rahman observes that with Ajeez, selling Atho has never merely been a business. With parents having lived in Burma, and leaving it behind for India, specifically Madras, as repatriates following the coup d'état in 1962, Ajeez views making and selling Atho as a bridge to his culture and people. This passion runs in the family. Rahman notes that his relatives operate similar Atho stalls in Trichy and Kutralam, further reinforcing food's known status as a mark of culture and community.

Legacy food should have secret recipes. Rahman insists there is no secret recipe; the true craft lies entirely in the balance of mixing and proportion. The shop caters to every craving with its main varieties: vegetarian, fried, and egg Atho, each customised to individual spice tolerances. Crucially, vegetarian and non-vegetarian preparation areas are kept strictly separate, ensuring no one's dietary preferences are compromised.

Ajeez operates from this spot for 20 years but has been in the Atho business for twice that number of years. After 40 years, he has found allies in his sons, Haider Ali and Yusuf. "On days my father-in-law is out of station or not well, his sons take care of the stall," observes Rahman.

And Rahman points out he does not assist in the running of the shop, just content being an avid Atho taster. And also volunteering to be a spokesperson, as he did for

Naturalised in Madras



Ajeez Atho Shop at Arrababu Street; and Shahul Hameed's shop at Second Line Beach Road in George Town.

this interview. Rahman points out the stall has appeared on several media platforms and attracted many VIPs who visit the stall during the less crowded hours.

Blurring of hierarchies

Shahul Hameed is the boss, and he is aged 30. Vincent Alphonse reports to Shahul at his Atho stall on Second Line Beach Road, and is more than twice his boss' age, having been born in 1962. The usual

hierarchical boss-worker relationship is missing. Deference to age does not entirely account for this behaviour. Shared histories and family connections explain it better. The forbears of both men are from Burma having come to Madras as repatriates following the 1962 coup. Repatriates Khadija Beevi and her husband started this shop 45 years ago and handed over its reins to their son Shahul. They have made sure their trusted lieute-

A dish's bio data

Here is Atho's biodata. Street food. Born in Burma. Naturalised in Madras. It is a hugely spicy form of noodles paired with shredded vegetables and the spiciness comes from a range of flavourings, which include chilli flakes, garlic, tamarind and fried onion. There is poetry to how it is made: the noodles along with its pairings is tossed by hand.

nant Vincent Alphonse who has worked with them for 30 years, is by their son's side assisting him. When his parents arrived in Madras from Burma in 1965, Alphonse was three years old, and his siblings were also children of tender years. Probably due to the effect of shared histories and family bonds and age, Shahul lets Vincent do the talking. One thing Vincent holds close to his heart is the customers telling him how conspicuous his absence is on the days he is not present in the shop. The cart draws bankers, lawyers, and college students, serving them vegetable, chicken, and fried Atho, alongside mohinga noodles traditionally accompanied by soup and banana stem. Vincent however notes mohinga has never matched Altho's popularity. Vincent says the secret of a good Atho moves far beyond its cooking process; it is in the mixing. Every component must come together correctly for the taste to emerge perfectly. He remarks fried atho is an entirely Indian twist to the Burmese dish. The cart employs around five people for smooth functioning. The sales dip during periods of religious abstinence from non-vegetarian food, but vegetable Atho sufficiently fills the gap and, Vincent says, has the highest demand. Vincent's composed voice could not hide his immense pride as he spoke about how the shop received a Vijay TV award for Best Navu (Meal) in 2012, an honour he credits to their taste. He adds that the shop holds an FSSAI certification, with employees having participated in food safety meetings.

Further down Second Line Beach Road, another Atho stall, called Burma Atho Shop, carries the same sense of a legacy being passed on. Rahamathulla took over the business from his uncle who had learnt the art of making Atho in Burma. And he makes it the way his uncle taught him. However, along the way, he has also tweaked Atho to suit local taste buds. His menu has grown to nearly 10 choices, spanning vegetable and fried Atho, including chicken and egg versions, with customers able to adjust the spice and flavours to their liking. And thereby he enables Burma, Madras and Chennai coexist, defying the limitations of time and geography.

As part of Madras Week, Resilience Series tracks traders and markets that have adapted to changing times and thrived in the city that was once called Madras



From a recent competition and (below) the team that won the second place at the national tournament.

A triumph both on and off the goalball court

Greater awareness about goalball needs to be created so that the visually challenged take it up

LIFFY THOMAS

Viewed at a surface level, the Tamil Nadu team's great showing in the Indian Blind Sports Association's "Second Youth National Goalball Championship 2026", where it took the second place, is just another victory in a sporting arena. At a deeper level, this victory signals other victories.

For one, it is a victory for the Goalball Association of Tamil Nadu, a registered body just a year old, for its successful efforts to stitch together a team comprising visually impaired students from small towns and difficult economic backgrounds. Many of them look at sports as a ticket to a stable government job.

R. Barath, a final year student of Presidency College, grew up in a joint family in Erode. His single father and uncle are visually challenged. Just three months ago, he learnt about the sport from a friend and got selected to the state team. "There are many blind students like me at Presidency College, Queen Mary's College and Nandanam Arts College. Conducting awareness sessions about this sport will encourage many more to join it and benefit they way I have," he says

A short put and javelin thrower, Ahilendiran D from Madurai got to



The history of it

Invented in 1946 as a rehabilitation sport for visually impaired World War II veterans, the sport evolved into a competitive discipline and gained international recognition. In 1976, Goalball was officially introduced as a Paralympic sport at the Toronto Paralympic Games. Played by two teams of three players each in an indoor court that roughly measures the size of a volleyball court (18mx9m), goalball relies on auditory skills, teamwork and tactical awareness. A bell inside the ball allows players to track movement through sound. All players wear opaque eye masks to allow players with varying degree of blindness to compete on an equal footing. Players roll or throw the ball hard along the floor to get it past the opposing team's defence and into a 9-metre-wide goal. Today, goalball is played in more than 100 countries and is said to be one of the most inspiring team sports in the Paralympic movement. For details, visit <https://tngoalball.in/> or call 93449 87893

know about goalball from his coach. An orphan, Ahilendiran supports his family taking up part-time jobs. After this victory, he hopes they get to compete in recognised competitions and more people and organisations come forward to sponsor them as well. Rajasthan Youth Association Foundation sponsored them for the just-concluded event.

A judo coach for the blind, V. Maheswaran from Salem was roped in to coach the boys team noticing the interest he showed in the para sport. He picked up the sport watching videos online and with the help of his son. "We all are learning and getting better with every competition. When we had the selection camp in Chennai, we sought help from members of Telangana team," says Maheswaran. Proud that three of his judo students have landed government jobs, he says, sports is not a level-playing field especially for those with disabilities and more organisations should come to empower students to take up sports.

For the national tournament, participants have to wear an eye patch but each costs more than ₹ 3,000, so we just tied a black cloth and played, he says.

Finding new talent

Visually challenged G.R. Bharathi Raja, who started the Tamil Nadu Blind Football Association in 2019, is also coaching students in goalball. He says goalball is specially designed for those with vision problems and teaches players life skills, builds physical strength and helps with coordination.

The Association is looking at conducting more awareness workshops in schools and colleges about goalball. Their first workshop had 45 students participating in it. "We are happy to visit institutions with visually challenged students to conduct more sessions and groom a new generation of players," says Bharathi Raja, who works with Indian Bank.

Besides accessible facilities to play and practise, the sport needs support on many other fronts.

Vidyashankar B, chairperson, Goalball Association of Tamil Nadu, wants the State Government to reward players who win national and international tournaments with cash awards.

Bringing players together at one space is a challenge. "If every district allots a space in a stadium for goalball then it saves the travel time, cost incurred for food and accommodation for many of these players who come from humble backgrounds," says Vidyashankar, who works with an IT company and is grateful to the support from Lit the Light Trust where he was a volunteer.

Finally, for players with visual disabilities it is not just about winning medals but to show to the world they can compete in a para sport.



An open well in Besant Nagar.

FILE PHOTO: KARUNAKARAN M

With the right design, an open well need not be a space taker; it can instead offer space for parking or anything else in addition to providing water-related benefits, as these communities in Chennai discovered with the help of The Rain Centre

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

For many apartment residents in Chennai, an open well may sound like something from another time – a structure with a parapet wall, a pulley and a bucket. With space at a premium, keeping one may seem impractical. But an open well does not necessarily mean giving up a parking spot or valuable open space. With the right design, it can be built below ground, allowing vehicles to pass over it while the well continues to collect rainwater and recharge groundwater.

This is what N. Ramshankar, an executive member of The Rain Centre, has done at the Rain Centre in Adyar. An old open well that once had only about two feet of water now holds around 16 feet after rooftop rainwater was direct-

Park your car over your open well

ed into it with minimal filtration.

Sekhar Raghavan, director, The Rain Centre, weighs in about this open well on the premises of the Rain Centre: “Unless I open the lid, you will not even know that there is an open well below.” Such wells can even be incorporated into driveways or parking areas, Sekhar says, provided they are kept away from structural columns. “You can have your open well within your stilt car parking,” says Sekhar. The minimum space required for the well, according to him, is about 3.25 feet in diameter.

“We were afraid in the initial days. We were wondering whether an open well can be closed and whether it will accumulate gas and all that. An engineer told us, ‘Don’t make that mistake, nothing will happen.’ He even set up a vent for us,” says Ramshankar. The parapet wall was subsequently removed and a slab was placed at floor level. “We demolished the parapet wall of the well and then we put a slab on it, at the floor level. Now we have vehicles going on top of it,” he says.

The benefit has not been limited to saving space. The quality of

the water has also improved. “The TDS has also been diluted from almost 850 to now 400,” he says.

For Ramshankar, the value of an open well lies in what it can provide while also being replenished. Open wells generally tap the shallow aquifer, around 25 to 30 feet below the ground and, at most, about 40 feet. Unlike the deeper hard-rock aquifer tapped by borewells, this shallow groundwater can be replenished more easily through rainwater harvesting. Rooftop rainwater can be directed into an existing well, replenishing the water and helping dilute salts and TDS.

Sekhar Raghavan says open wells generally tap the shallow groundwater layer, which can be replenished through rainwater harvesting.

“During monsoon, your open well will have a lot of water, and a couple of months thereafter. So,

We made these collection pits at every gate and diverted the water to the percolation pits.

start tapping it. Then during summer months, go to your borewell,” he says. For an apartment, this can also translate into a reduction in dependence on tanker water.

Keeping the tankers away

At Hiranya Apartments in Raja Annamalaipuram, resident Raghunandan Ranganathan says the open well was never shut, even though three borewells had been installed and two were later closed. “This open well is what is giving us a lot of water,” he says.

The apartment already had rainwater-harvesting infrastructure, including percolation wells. But during heavy rain, water would collect in the compound and flow out through the gates onto the road. The residents then sought Sekhar Raghavan's help.

“We made these collection pits at every gate and diverted the water to the percolation pits, which in turn were feeding the well,” says Raghunandan. Over time, the system changed the quality and availability of water in the apartment.

“Builders often do not make use of the open wells available on

a property. Instead, they tend to shut them down and install borewells. I am not able to understand the logic behind this.”

Making use of the monsoon

At Bayview Apartments in Besant Nagar, the open well has been in use since the apartment was built around 1989-90. “We are using an open well. Generally, during the rain, mainly after the Northeast Monsoon, it fills up,” says resident K. Sangameshwar.

The apartment also has two borewells and a Metro Water connection. During the rainy season, residents use more of the open well and borewell. Rainwater from the terrace is directed towards the ground, with parts of the system leading close to the open well. The complex also has rainwater-harvesting pits in its open areas. “So all these go into the well, and from the well, I think it slowly percolates into the groundwater,” says Sangameshwar.

Unlike the well at The Rain Centre, the Bayview well remains above ground, with a cover and mesh over it. It shows that there is no single way for an apartment to retain an open well. It can remain visible in an open space, or it can be covered and integrated into a driveway or parking area.

For apartment residents, then, the question may not be whether there is enough space for an open well. It could be whether the space already available can be put to better use – above the ground for parking, and below it for water



Galactic Club gets students curious about space

The Department of Mathematics of Stella Maris College organised a host of events to celebrate National Space Day

The Galactic Club of the Department of Mathematics, Stella Maris College organised the National Space Day celebration on August 24 to promote awareness of space science and celebrate India's achievements in space exploration. This year, the celebrations were centred on the theme, 'Towards Viksit Bharat - Innovating, Collaborating and Aspiring Global Space Leadership'. The programme featured four major

▼ One of the winning teams at the prize distribution ceremony.

competitions catering to both school and college students and a talk on "Future of Space Science in India".

School students participated in Cosmic Quest, a Space Olympiad that tested their knowledge of space and astronomy and Celestial Creations, a space-themed painting competition that encouraged creativity and artistic expression. College students participated in Stellar Paints, a t-shirt painting competition and Astro Talk, a paper presentation that provided an opportunity to showcase their research, communication and presentation skills.

The chief guest for the space day celebrations was Bharathi Kannan R, Scientist-SE, Range Operation, SDSC SHAR, ISRO. The session provided students with valuable insights into space science, space exploration and future opportunities in the field. The programme also included a prize distribution ceremony, where the winners and participants of the various events were recognised and felicitated for their achievements and enthusiastic participation.

The club regularly organises a variety of activities, including space-themed competitions and sky-gazing events, encouraging students to learn, participate and develop a deeper interest in astronomy and space science, added the release.

Sevalaya's 38-year journey in reel

A documentary film commemorating Sevalaya's 38-year journey of service was released on August 25 at Arkay Convention Centre, Mylapore. Thambi Thamizharasan, Editor-in-Chief, Maalai Murasu TV, graced the occasion and released the film.

The Chief Guest along with popular speaker Isaikavi Ramanan and Sundar, Sevalaya supporter and nephew of Chellamma Bharathi, lit the traditional lamp and garlanded the portraits of Bharathi, Gandhi and Vivekananda to mark the beginning of the event.

The video captures Sevalaya's 38-year journey from its beginnings in 1988, when it started by providing education to five children rescued from brick kilns in Tiruvallur district. It showcases Sevalaya's work in education, healthcare, care for destitute children and elders, rural development, skill development, organic farming, environmental protection and animal welfare, contributing to improving the lives of nearly 20,00,000 people across seven states in India.

Final day of Pothys 'Kolusu Kondattam'

Pothys Swarna Mahal, a leading jewellery retailer, has brought tradition and contemporary style with its 'Kolusu Kondattam' mela, held across its showrooms in the State. Featuring an impressive collection of over 5,000 designs, the mela offers customers an extensive choice of plain, antique, and designer silver anklets.

Customers can purchase plain silver

anklets with no making charges and GST. Customers will pay only for the silver weight and the prevailing silver rate. In addition, antique and fancy designer anklets are available at a 10 percent discount off the maximum retail price, said a release.

The showrooms are on GST Road, Chromepet; Rukmani Nagar, Poona-mallee; C.T.H. Road, Padi; and in Coim-batore, Salem, Tirunelveli, and Trichy.

Televisions with RGB technology

Sony launched its latest 'Bravia True RGB Televisions' at an event held at Girias Showroom in Mahalingapuram.

Sony is committed to delivering superior picture quality and an immersive viewing experience through its innovative True RGB technology, said a release. To celebrate the festive season, the multinational conglomerate has announced a special promotional offer on its newly launched Bravia True RGB televisions. Customers can avail attractive cashback offers, a 1-EMI-free scheme, and a complimentary three-year warranty. The new Bravia True RGB Televisions are now available at Girias showrooms, the release added.

Musical programme for a cause

Satrangi's next presentation will be held on August 30 from 6 p.m. onwards at Chinmaya Heritage Centre, Harrington Road, Chetpet. This programme will feature memorable songs sung by Indian Idol Top Winner Avirbhav, Anirvinhya, Promod and Smriti supported by a live orchestra.

This programme is in aid of RMD Nursing Training for Girls. Donor passes for this event are priced at ₹5000/₹2500/₹1200/ ₹800 and will be home delivered on calling 9884778073.

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Coding their way to confidence

From village classrooms to a State-level competition at IIT-M Research Park, young minds are making their mark with digital skills



KANNAL ACHUTHAN

When Iniyasri, a school student from Uthukottai in Thiruvallur district, learnt that she would be making a visit to IIT-Madras this month, she simply could not contain her joy. She was one of the students to be selected to make a presentation that would reflect the digital and computer literacy skills that she had acquired with the help of the Chennai chapter of voluntary organisation Asha for Education.

"Last time, I was not selected to come to IIT, but this time I made it," says Iniyasri, who is now learning Scratch at a rural training centre (RTC) run by Asha. She showed off her newly acquired skills with a project on the universe at a competition where students from 13 RTCs across Tamil Nadu

participated.

Volunteers at Asha Chennai have worked steadily to bring the RTC programme to this point. The programme that started with just two RTCs in 2022 has now grown into a thriving initiative reaching nearly 1,200 students. The RTCs provide free six-month courses for students from Classes 6 to 12. While every centre begins with digital literacy, students can progress to programming, web development, robotics and AI as their skills develop.

The excitement of the students, most of whom were from government schools in villages, could hardly be contained within the walls of Raman Hall in the IIT-M Research Park during the competition. Rather than allow the high-pressure environment to dampen their spirits, the students confidently showed their projects to the experts who had come to judge the event. The 18 judges included pro-

fessionals from Amazon, Ford, Accenture, Cisco, Wipro and several start-up companies. Professors from Rajalakshmi Engineering College and BITS Pilani were also among the judges.

This round in the State capital saw students from 13 centres submit 482 projects across digital literacy, Scratch programming, web development, physical computing, robotics, media editing, JavaScript animations and AI. Of these, 64 projects were selected for presentation at IIT-M. The projects reflected both the students' technical learning and their everyday interests. Scratch projects included games, science topics and environmental themes. Students working on websites tackled subjects ranging from agriculture to food delivery management. Robotics students developed ideas such as cleaning robots, pollution detectors and smart agriculture systems.



Glimpses of the event held at IIT-Madras. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Volunteer Rajaraman Krishnan, who has been with Asha Chennai for over two decades, said that students have been so engaged with the programme that many have continued attending the RTCs over the years. One of them is doing an internship with Asha Chennai now, he added.

Jayavel, one of the judges, said,

"The students were impressive, not just because of what they had built, but also because they had learned and understood their projects well and were able to explain their ideas clearly. It is great to see children getting the opportunity to learn technology, experiment with it, and build things on their own."

Madras Week celebrated on a train ride

When Madras Day arrived, Chennai welcomed it on the move with a musical Metro ride; the celebration was punctuated with a pause to show commuters how to use the Metro with civic sense

At the stroke of midnight, as August 22 turned into Madras Day, 150 Chennaiites boarded a Metro train at Chennai Central for a freshly aligned troika: music, community and Metro awareness. The three-fold experience was jointly organised by Super Chennai and Chennai Metro Rail

Limited (CMRL) to celebrate the city through moving snapshots of it, as well as appreciate its lifeline, the Metro that gives it movement.

At the Chennai Central Metro station, before the participants embarked on the Metro ride, a cake was cut by the CMRL mascot. On the ride, Chennai-based folk music en-



semble Office Gaana took their place across two compartments. Special arrangements ensured that passengers seated across both compartments could experience the concert. Office Gaana launched into one song after another in their distinctive folk style, turning the Metro into a moving sing-along, says a press re-

lease Passengers sang along, clapped, grooved and, at several points, even moved to the floor of the compartments to get closer to the music. For nearly an hour, the train became a celebration on wheels, travelling from Chennai Central to Arumbakkam and back.

The midnight ride doubled as a

Metro awareness initiative, with announcements and messages woven into the musical journey. Participants were reminded about simple but important aspects of using the Metro responsibly – allowing passengers to alight before boarding, keeping the coaches clean, following safety guidelines, respecting fellow commuters and making the best use of the Metro system. J Roddick, one of the participants, travelled from Padur in OMR.

"The moment they opened registrations, I thought this was going to be one insane experience that I should not miss," he said. "Madras Day has grown tremendously over the years, with people from different walks of life coming together to celebrate the city. We wanted to create an experience that reflected the Chennai of today – young, energetic, rooted in its culture, but constantly looking for new experiences," said Ranjeeth Rathod, MD, Super Chennai.